

WHERE CAN I GO FOR HELP AND SUPPORT?

There are plenty of avenues of support that you can explore to help you manage when taking care of your special-care baby.

» **Your partner:** sometimes asking for help from your partner can be a trigger for him to feel more involved and positive himself.

» **Your pediatrician:** when you're home, your pediatrician will want to see his new patient within a few days. Ask him or her anything you need to know about your baby or how to best take care of him.

» **Friends and family:** ask for practical help whenever you can. Close family and good friends will want to do all they can to ease your load.

» **Other parents:** the social worker assigned to your baby in the neonatal intensive care unit can put you in touch with other parents who have been through a similar situation. Many hospitals run support groups for the parents of their special-care babies.

» **A counselor:** ask your doctor about seeing a counselor, or, if you had a neonatal counselor in the hospital, arrange to speak to him or her. Talking things through with an impassive observer can help you unload without fear of judgment.

» **The Internet:** Organizations like the nonprofit March of Dimes, which are designed to help parents of preemie babies, have online chat rooms, local chapters and e-newsletters.

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Take one day at a time

Making plans or giving yourself deadlines will only add to your load. Instead, try to enjoy every moment and every day for what it is, and to relish the stage that your baby has reached. Give yourself permission to roll with the punches.

Supporting each other

Though you and your partner will react in your own ways to the pressures of taking care of your baby, it's best to try to work as a team. Assign roles so you both feel valued and included, and that you're contributing your individual strengths. Your partner may also to be worried about you. Suggest practical ways for him to help, such as making you a "packed lunch" before he goes to work, or taking responsibility for the dishes. Encourage him, too, to have some skin-to-skin time with the baby to help them bond.

Mothers of babies who have spent time in intensive care have a higher risk of postpartum depression (PPD), so be aware of the symptoms (see p.263). Sharing how you feel each day will help to keep you connected, and for you to feel supported.

Time together Once home with your baby, you can enjoy a new sense of closeness.